C1 Listening

News reports: main idea and detail

Separate the main story from supporting detail and background in a short radio news item.

News reports follow a pattern: the main point comes first, then details, quotes and background. Knowing this structure helps you decide what to note and what to let go.

Part	What it contains	Typical signals
Headline sentence	Who did what, the core change	The first sentence
Details	Numbers, places, dates	*The plan includes... From next month...*
Reaction	What people say about it	*said, welcomed, criticised*
Background	Why it is happening now	*The move follows... Last year...*

Listen

Summarise in ten words. After listening, try to state the main idea in ten words or fewer. If you can, you have understood the story.

Common mistake. Treating the background or a reaction as the main point. The internet problem is important, but it is a reaction, not the news itself.

Practice

1. Summarise the main point in no more than ten words.
2. Give two details about how the plan will work.
3. How did the teachers' association react?
4. What background reason is given for the change?

5. Which of these is background, not the main news? (a) coding becomes compulsory (b) fewer than one in five graduates could program

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Transcript

The Ministry of Education has announced that coding will become a compulsory subject in all secondary schools from next September. Students will have two lessons a week, and around five hundred new teachers will be trained over the summer. The teachers' association welcomed the decision but warned that many schools still lack reliable internet access. The move follows a report last year showing that fewer than one in five graduates had basic programming skills, a figure the ministry described as a serious concern for the economy.

Answers

1. For example: Coding becomes compulsory in secondary schools from September.
2. Two lessons a week; about 500 new teachers trained over the summer.
3. It welcomed the decision but warned that many schools lack reliable internet.
4. A report last year found fewer than one in five graduates had basic programming skills.
5. (b)